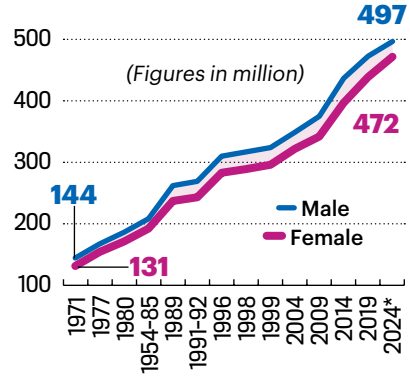
A RISING TIDE

MORE WOMEN ARE REGISTERING FOR THEIR VOTE AND TURNING

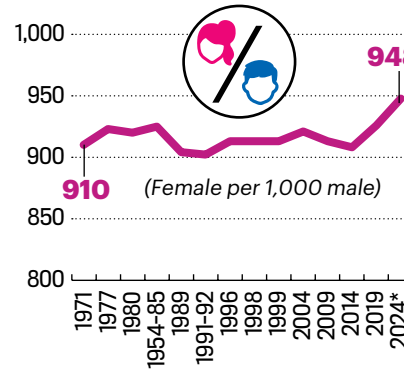
REGISTERED VOTERS

There's been a 260% rise in the female electorate since 1971 compared to 245% in case of men



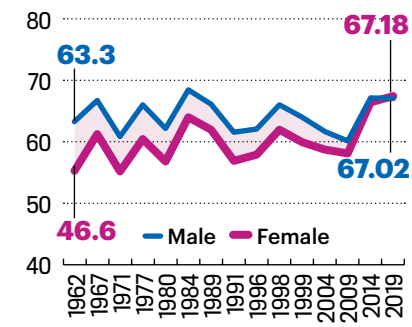
GENDER RATIO

The ratio of women electors has taken a turn for the better since 2019



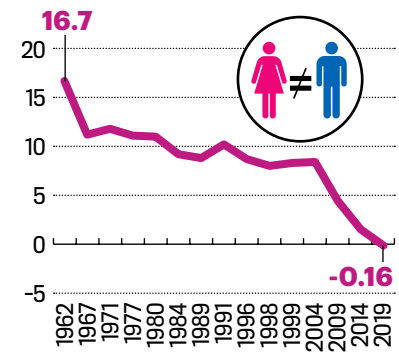
VOTER TURNOUT (%)

Women voter turnout has shown a higher rise over men since 1962 when gender data was first published



GENDER GAP (%)

The gap between male and female voter turnouts narrowed in 2014 and turned negative in 2019



Source: Election Commission of India

**As on Feb. 8, 2024*

IT WAS A TINY SLIVER—A MERE 0.16 PERCENTAGE POINTS—BUT IT BECAME THE BIGGEST STORY OF THE 2019 general election. That year, for the first time in India's parliamentary history, the turnout of women voters (67.18 per cent) exceeded that for men (67.02), reversing the gender gap. It was a small step, but it made Indian women equal arbiters of the nation's political destiny. And the tide is only rising. This election, there has been a 7.5 per cent increase in the number of registered women voters, to 471 million from 438 million in 2019, higher than the five per cent for men. It will include 8.5 million first-time women voters, or those who have attained voting age. The gender elector ratio, or the number of women per 1,000 men, too, has gone up, to 948 from 926 in the previous election. There are 12 states, in fact, where this ratio is in favour of women this year compared to eight in 2019.

Across the length and breadth of the country, this silent revolution has already begun to have a significant impact. The power of the woman vote was one of the major factors that propelled Narendra Modi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to total dominance in both the 2014 and 2019 general elections. According to an analysis by Axis My India, a reputed polling agency, as many as 46 per cent of the women voted for the BJP in 2019 compared to 44 per cent of the men. Women voters, in fact, have become the backbone of the ruling party.

The fact that both national and regional parties have focused on schemes to improve their lot indicates that the woman vote is much sought-after. In a landmark legislation in September 2023, the Modi government passed the Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, reserving one-third of all seats for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, including those reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. Women already have a significant share in the Union government's central schemes—27 per cent in PMJJBY (Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana), 37 per cent in PMSBY (Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana), 44 per cent in APY (Atal Pension Yojana), 68 per cent in MUDRA loans and 81 per cent in Stand-up India, according to SBI Research.

Graphics by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**